



Building an innovative sustainability culture through ESG certification



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Abstract With the growing focus on organizations' environmental, social, and governance (ESG) performance, many companies consider obtaining certifications that attest to the sustainability of their products, processes, or organization. The multitude of available certifications to choose from, however, can cloud decision-making when seeking the right certification. Certifications can also be costly, and compliance with their requirements can be onerous. At the same time, organizations also tend to struggle with aspects of building innovative cultures to find ESG solutions—notably, processes and resources. This article first demonstrates that ESG certifications and their required compliance can fill in the missing gaps in innovative cultures—fostering rather than hindering them—and then provides a framework for managers to consider when evaluating sustainability certifications. Compliance with certification has often been thought to impede innovation, but we link this decision-making process to supporting a culture of innovation within the organization, increasing the likelihood of innovative solutions to ESG problems.

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1. Seeking certification

With increased focus on organizations' environmental, social, and governance (ESG) performance, many companies seeking recognition for environmentally friendly processes, products, and services

turn to various ESG certifications that demonstrate their efforts to customers, investors, and other organizations. However, these organizations may be unsure of how to engage in ESG certification, choose an appropriate certification, and evaluate the costs and effort associated with attaining it.

Examples of certifications include those for the entire organization (e.g., BCorp; [Moroz et al., 2018](#); [Parker et al., 2019](#)), for a product (e.g., biodynamics; [Fox & Wilson, 2023](#); [Lahneman, 2015](#)), and for investments (e.g., green bonds; [Flammer,](#)

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2020, 2021). There are over 3,000 BCorps in the US, and almost 9,500 globally.¹ The Climate Bonds Initiative (CBI), a certifier of green bonds, has 785 debt instruments certified under its standards, representing \$335.24 billion.² The overall number of such certifications is also large and growing. The Ecolabel Index tracks over 450 certifications globally.³ Some of these have been criticized as greenwashing and can result in stakeholder backlash. For our purposes, we are considering valid certifications with rigorous frameworks that attest to the desired ESG attributes.

However, there are challenges with earning and maintaining such certifications and implementing the frameworks that underpin them. Some of them are obvious (e.g., cost), but even this aspect has indirect and hidden components. We address these challenges by providing a framework for engaging with the process and conducting an evaluation of potential ESG certifications. A thorough review of the various aspects should be conducted as part of a realistic and transparent process. This review should include consideration of how the certification will influence and possibly close the gaps within the organization's innovative culture, as well as support progress toward innovative solutions for ESG-related problems. We focus on small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) operating in developed economies, as these organizations have suffered challenges with certification and innovation (Parker et al., 2019; Parrilli et al., 2025). At the same time, certifications offer these organizations tremendous potential for contributing to sustainable development (Carvalho et al., 2022). The Innovative ESG Certification Framework helps SME leaders navigate the certification process and enhance a firm's innovative culture and performance.

2. ESG certifications: Too much of a good thing?

Organizations often obtain certifications to signal their orientation to ESG-related issues (Gehman & Grimes, 2017) and set themselves apart from other companies (Fox & Wilson, 2023). Gehman et al. (2019) describe these types of certifications along three common themes: (1) they provide standards that organizations then adopt and adhere to; (2) they require some sort of assessment of compliance with those standards; and (3) they provide

some sort of designation (e.g., badges, labels, symbols, etc.).

There are various related reasons why organizations would adopt them. Producers that adopt sustainable practices as part of their business model (Martin, 2015) want to ensure they are recognized as such (Gehman & Grimes, 2017), and some companies use sustainability as a marketing tool (Baldasarré & Campo, 2016). ESG rating agencies—which measure corporate activity against ESG metrics and provide scores—serve as an important information source for investors and pressure companies to demonstrate their sustainability (Fiaschi et al., 2020).

Organizations that adopt certifications as part of their business model are demonstrating their environmental or prosocial orientation, as well as improving their innovation and design processes. In the fashion industry, for example, Escudero et al. (2023, p. 6) showed how certification supports product design and innovation with “eco-friendly materials and timeless design.”

Adopting eco-labels just for the sake of marketing can be perceived as *greenwashing* when it comes to environmental claims (Delmas & Grant, 2014) or *bluewashing* when it comes to prosocial claims (Escudero et al., 2023), causing negative backlash. The success achieved in realizing the energy and water efficiency claims of projects financed by green bond issues can only tenuously be linked to the project itself—and even then, only under certain circumstances (Devine & McCollum, 2024). The marketing claims associated with these bonds may be met with investor skepticism.

Certifications do, however, provide positive marketing outcomes (Delmas & Grant, 2014). In the wine industry, for example, certification can signal innovative business practices and a commitment to quality—as well as an ESG orientation (Flores, 2018). Flammer (2021) found that green bonds effectively and credibly signal a commitment to the environment. Certification also projects the companies' legitimacy in an industry that is known for both environmental and social issues like the fashion industry described by Escudero et al. (2023). This anchoring of sustainability outcomes is especially beneficial for SMEs (Carvalho et al., 2022).

However, like the backlash against compliance with mandated regulations (e.g., Sarbanes-Oxley compliance; Gao & Zhang, 2019), some suggest that compliance with certification assessments takes away the focus on business processes and growth. Parker et al. (2019), in particular, demonstrated their potential to divert attention away from running the business with organizations

¹ <https://www.bcorporation.net/en-us/find-a-b-corp/>

² <https://www.climatebonds.net/certification/certified-bonds>

³ <https://www.ecolabelindex.com/>

paying a growth penalty, and the smallest and youngest companies sacrificing the most value.

Gehman and Grimes (2017), on the other hand, argued that certifications reflect and reinforce values practices, that there are innovative companies trying to solve ESG problems, and that certifications can attest to this. In addition, we suggest that the processes and intellectual capital required for compliance can close the cultural gaps that exist within organizations—even despite their sincere ESG orientation—which would otherwise prevent innovative solutions to ESG problems. The framework presented in Figure 1 provides guidance for leaders pursuing ESG certification who are also concerned about innovation and overall firm performance.

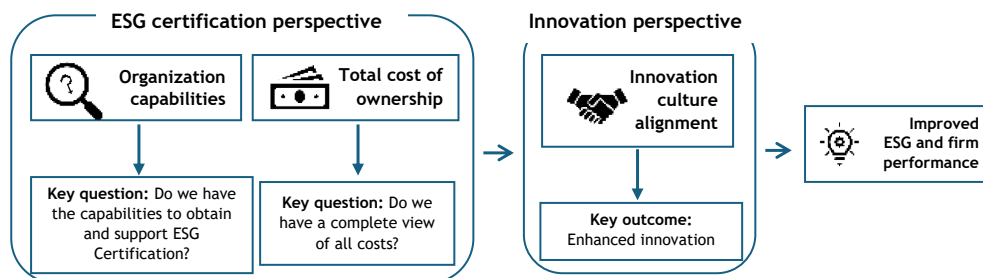
3. Innovative ESG certification framework: Compatibility and closing gaps

There are two general categories of attributes to consider when assessing the suitability of ESG certification: (1) the compatibility with organizational goals and (2) the potential to influence and close gaps in innovative culture. These attributes frame the Innovative ESG Certification Framework and the discussion that follows. Compatibility with organizational goals warrants consideration of organizational capabilities to meet the requirements of the certification process and of the costs to do so. The potential for certifications to close gaps in innovative culture requires consideration of the certification's attributes in relation to the innovation gaps in the corporate culture. We draw on examples illustrated by building construction criteria (the International Living Future Institute; ILFI), green debt (the Climate Bond Initiative), organizational level criteria (B Corp), and biodynamic certification (on agriculture food and wine products and processes).

These certifications provide good examples of the type Gehman et al. (2019) described (as noted above) and require rigorous certification processes. While not exhaustive by any means, they cover a range of industry-specific, finance-related, organizational-level, and product/process-specific characteristics.

The ILFI provides certification programs for the built environment (e.g., certifying buildings as Zero Energy or Zero Carbon), as well as the highest and most rigorous criteria (e.g., the Living Building Challenge). There are performance measures that must be met, and compliance with certification is assessed by a third party to a level of assurance that is akin to an audit. The Climate Bond Initiative (CBI) has a mandate to mobilize debt markets toward climate action. They provide certification for debt issues (green bonds and green loans) that follows a rigorous process, building on the framework provided by the green bond principles of the International Capital Markets Association. The assurance required for initial certification must be performed by an independent third party. Ongoing assurance over the use of funds is also required. *B Corp* is an organization-wide certification that measures an organization's social and environmental impact across five categories: (1) governance, (2) workers, (3) community, (4) environment, and (5) customers. Its certification is conducted as a review by B Lab, the not-for-profit organization that devised the criteria. *Biodynamics* is a processes and practices certification for an agricultural product. It is the oldest organic certification, and producers must be fully certified organic prior to obtaining biodynamic certification. Biodynamics is seen as an Environmental Certified Management Standard (ECMS), providing guidelines for biodynamic conversion and compliance (Lahneman, 2015). The biodynamic certification itself, overseen by Demeter International, requires extensive recordkeeping by tracking the timing,

Figure 1. Innovative ESG Certification Framework



frequency, and quantity of the prescribed biodynamic preparations.

4. ESG certification perspective

There is, of course, a relationship between organizational capabilities and the costs associated with certification (i.e., if the organization does not have what is required to comply with certification, there may be additional costs to acquire the necessary expertise or production resources). Before getting to costs, however, whether the certification is right for the organization can be considered via what the organization must bring to the certification and what the certification brings to the organization.

The main questions to consider are (1) whether the organization has the capabilities to meet the requirements of compliance and (2) whether the certification has different levels or standards. Aspects of the former include resources and personnel, time and timing, visibility and benefits, complementary or conflicting regulatory barriers, and costs (further analyzed in Section 4.2.). Aspects of the latter include changing certification criteria.

4.1. Organizational capabilities

4.1.1. Resources and personnel

What are the resources required to obtain certification, and does the organization have them? Resources may include the machinery, equipment, and facilities to comply with something like a product or production certification. However, they may also refer to the supply chain, including compliant raw materials, certified suppliers, and appropriate customers. Some certifications for an entire organization require knowledge of both suppliers and customers, as well as the source of inputs and the use of outputs.

Trained and qualified personnel may be required to meet certification requirements, which may also entail additional certifications for staff, management, and external consultants. There may be specific knowledge that is required (e.g., ongoing reporting necessary for a CBI-certified green bond issue that begs an understanding of sustainable finance and/or sustainability reporting standards). For specific products or processes, the International Living Future Institute (ILFI) requires a member of the organization to be accredited by their standards (Living Future Accreditation; LFA). Like many professional designations, this requires ongoing professional development and annual fees to maintain.

4.1.2. Certification time frame

How long it takes to become certified should be considered in relation to desired outcomes and business cycles. If the process can be aligned with other processes (e.g., the accounting cycle or production cycle), it may make sense. If it frustrates other cycles or requires additional record-keeping and resource allocation, it may not. In relation to the compliance time frame, organizations must ask: Will we be able to meet certification deadlines with production stage requirements?

Regarding the certification itself, some certifications are in a state of flux, as are popular trends, and the questions of whether the certifier moved on to something new in the time it takes to achieve one certification or whether the public moved on to a more niche version—or something entirely different—become important. If the certifier is changing the existing certification, will support for the current version eventually expire? Alternatively, will the standards for the existing certification change, making compliance increasingly onerous and resource-consuming?

4.1.3. Visibility and benefits

If the certification is new, there may be a benefit to being a first mover and early adapter. This can be compared to a well-established and well-respected certification that has had public exposure and stood the test of time.

4.1.4. Regulatory barriers

Just as there are trends and fads affecting certification development and public perception, governments and scientific research are often affected by current topics. Government regulation can be hard to predict, and acting administrations may suddenly change direction, or new administrations may undertake new initiatives. The nature of the scientific process means that new knowledge renders older knowledge obsolete and affects social trends and aforementioned government regulations. This could result in both tried and true certifications as well as newly minted ones potentially becoming obsolete.

4.2. Total cost of ownership

When contemplating costs, all costs must be considered, including the related and hidden ones. Some of these are direct, indirect, fixed, variable, and ongoing. There is also the cost of failure to consider. The term *total cost of ownership*, popular in supply chain and accounting, refers to understanding the complete view of costs and cost

categories that are relevant for making purchasing decisions (Swamidass, 2000).

4.2.1. Direct costs

In addition to any certification fees, the direct costs of certification may include the costs of adding systems required for tracking performance data, upgrading existing systems, or the cost of third-party assurance. There may need to be a designated professional on the internal team, training for staff, and outside consultants to assist with compliance. This may include memberships in organizations and ongoing professional development costs or salaries and wages associated with hiring qualified personnel. Some technically intense certifications (e.g., the ILFI LCC) require a team member to be Living Future Accredited and may require engineering or architectural consultants versed in the certification standards to ensure compliance.

4.2.2. Indirect costs

Some indirect costs might include those of ensuring that suppliers, customers, or complementary products are compliant with the certification. For example, certifications may require additional recordkeeping, which may result in higher salaries and wage expenses. In addition, they may require gathering information about suppliers or customers and vetting relationships if upstream or downstream compliance is a condition of certification.

4.2.3. Fixed costs

The certification itself may come with an annual fee or subscription. Fixed costs may also include the cost of annual assurance that is fixed within a relevant range and might be a singular or recurring fee for the life of the certification. The ILFI LCC certification has fees associated with review and revision at the various steps toward certification as a pathway to progress toward the final assessment. The Climate Bond Initiative has a third-party assurance requirement for initial certification at bond issue, as well as ongoing reporting. The ongoing reporting represents a cost for the life of the certification (i.e., until the bonds mature).

4.2.4. Ongoing costs

Ongoing costs can be a combination of some of the above but require consideration, as the organization may suffer reputational damage if the certification is not maintained. An example of a significant ongoing cost is that associated with CBI certification. Subsequent to initial certification and the bond issue, the use of proceeds requires

ongoing reporting. In addition to the required third-party assurance over the framework compliance, there is additional assurance required for reporting where the money went to ensure that it went to the project supported by the green bond. This requires ongoing record-keeping and an increase in professional fees for more assurance.

4.2.5. Failure costs

Failure to achieve certification goes beyond the sunk costs associated with the attempt. Failure to achieve a very visible certification—like that for a green bond—may result in reputation damage that may limit the organization's ability to maintain its social license to operate in certain jurisdictions or with certain communities. For example, if a bond issue was meant to support property development within communities that have climate crisis-driven mandates for green buildings, failure to achieve green bond certification may call into question the organization's ability to deliver on its promises. Further, it may also result in higher costs in terms of a forgone *greenium*, represented by reduced interest rates and demand-driven pricing over the subscription. Whether or not failure to achieve certification will adversely affect the company could be a major consideration.

4.3. Different levels of certification

Some certifications have different levels of performance, subcriteria, and precursors or steps to be satisfied. The ILFI—which certifies building projects, for example—has various levels leading up to full certification. Full *Living Building Challenge (LBC) Certification* is based on satisfying all of the 20 imperatives for the various seven “petals” (e.g., water or energy), but it offers steps toward full LBC compliance and will certify buildings as Zero Energy or Zero Carbon if they meet the key imperatives. This offers a fallback if an organization/building fails to achieve full LBC certification.

On the other hand, B Corp—in its attempt to measure an organization's social and environmental impact—has impact measures across its five categories. An organization may excel in one area, while being at a relative deficit in another, thereby meeting a different level within the criteria.

4.3.1. Evolution of certification criteria

Whether the certification is in flux may be as pertinent as whether it has stagnated and become old news. For many certifying organizations trying to keep up with the multitude of other options, criteria and certifications are often in a constant state of revision and expansion. Certifiers continue to refine

and adjust their criteria, changing standards to expand and contract categories and subcategories. In addition, they continue to offer more niche certifications, appealing to trends as the focus changes. This can make ongoing compliance a moving target and may result in eventual failure to attain the standard. Conversely, stagnation may mean that the certification did indeed go out of style and out of touch with changing trends.

5. Innovation perspective

With respect to ESG certification, innovation is an important aspect to consider for several reasons. Innovation has been shown to be a key tenet of firm performance. Quite simply, innovative firms outperform noninnovative firms. Therefore, it is important for leaders to understand how ESG certification may or may not impact an organization's innovation agenda. There is a belief by scholars that "tightening" processes like certifications, audits, and robust procedures can act as a strong control (Simons, 1994). Although controls may be beneficial, acting as a boundary system for unwarranted behavior, one of the side effects is that they dampen creativity and innovation. However, innovation is also very contextual, and our view is that in the context of innovation, certifications help innovation by enhancing the innovation culture. Our view is based on three research-based findings from multiple innovation culture studies that we have performed.

A strong innovation culture is well established as a critical determinant of innovation (Dobni & Klassen, 2021; Govindarajan & Trimble, 2005) and firm performance (Crossan & Apaydin, 2010). For the studies we performed across an array of industries and countries, high (low) innovating firms have strong (weak) innovation cultures. High innovating firms also outperform low innovators on critical cultural determinants like leadership, knowledge management, process, and resources (Dobni & Klassen, 2015, 2018; Klassen et al., 2020; Wilson et al., 2023). An investigation of these studies and related research provides insight into the importance of innovation culture for ESG and the relevance of certification and certification processes. Our innovation insights toward certifications and the certification process focus on three aspects of innovation culture: (1) the innovation process, (2) collaboration with third parties, and (3) methods and technologies. Our view is that ESG certifications enhance innovation culture alignment and position leaders for improved ESG and firm performance.

5.1. ESG certification supports the innovation process

The innovation studies have consistently shown that processes to advance innovation are stubborn and difficult for leaders trying to improve innovation culture. ESG certification can be beneficial to support the innovation process by addressing three key drivers of the innovation process: (1) idea management, (2) employee empowerment, and (3) organizational measurement. Multiple studies have shown that the process aspect of innovation execution is significantly weaker than innovation drivers like resources, knowledge management, and leadership. For example, organizational leaders are better at communicating an innovation vision than they are at idea management (i.e., a process to advance an innovative idea; Dobni & Klassen, 2021; Wilson et al., 2023). These studies further articulate that from a process perspective, organizations are better at empowering employees than they are at organizational measurement and idea management. The parallels to ESG are striking, as employees are ready to act on ESG but are constrained by processes to move ESG initiatives forward. Certifications can provide a mechanism to move an idea forward and are a key catalyst for having an innovative culture and advancing ESG. Organizational skills, creativity, and empowerment will be more effective if supplemented with certification processes. The ESG certification can legitimize alignment via measurement and address this weak construct, and rigorous certifications provide validity to the measures and activities of the organization. Studies have also reported that organizations that measure innovation and have strong performance measurement systems outperform those that do not (Dobni et al., 2015; Klassen et al., 2023). For example:

To the extent that a certification provides a process toward desired sustainable outcomes, it can close the process gap in an innovation culture. Biodynamic certification, as an example of an Environment Certified Management Standard, provides guidelines for the preparation, application, and measurement of organic treatments that drive sustainable outcomes.

5.2. ESG certification third parties support innovation collaboration

Collaborating with third parties is often researched via the lens of open innovation, which has also consistently been found to support an innovation

culture (Chesbrough & Appleyard, 2007; Dobni & Klassen, 2021). *Open innovation* involves working with external parties like vendors to collaborate on innovation. Similar to how a firm engages with a vendor on process development, pro-ESG organizations can engage third parties via the certification processes, which will adapt and change as knowledge transfer and learning occurs. A more recent study of open innovation suggested a cautionary note in which too much collaborating and divulging competitive insight can reduce the performance impact of open innovation (Wilson et al., 2023). The content of collaboration between organizations and certification parties would be much less strategically important and mitigate this issue. For example:

Certification often requires working closely with both the certifying organization and potentially a third-party assessor. LCC certification requires consultation with the ILFI throughout the path to certification, with the ILFI ultimately serving as the assessor of compliance with the criteria. CBI certification of a green bond issue requires a third-party assessment done by auditors specializing in sustainability initiatives. The assessment process engenders collaboration with the organization and information exchange and improvement.

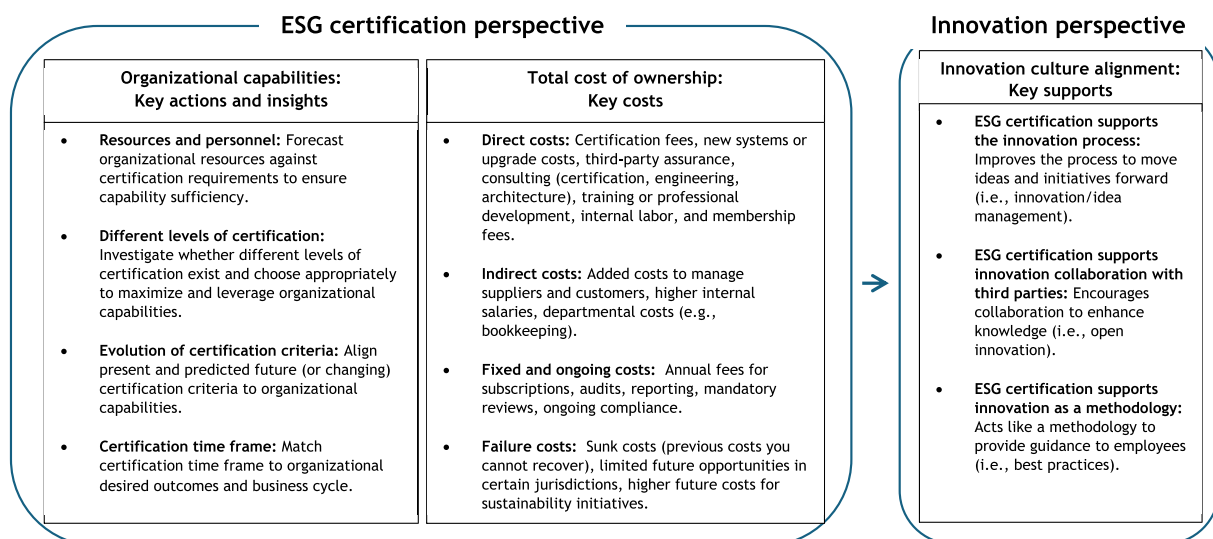
5.3. ESG certification behaves like an innovation methodology

The third relevant stream of innovation culture research relates to the methods and technologies

that support innovation culture. Examples of methods and tools used in these studies include design thinking, prototype processes, crowd-sourcing, stage-gate, open innovation, big data analytics, scientific discovery, and innovation management software (Dobni & Klassen, 2021; Dobni et al., 2021, 2022). The relationship between methods and technologies and innovation is also being researched in newer settings like artificial intelligence (AI; Ferraro et al., 2024) and projectification (Lovett et al., 2025). A global innovation survey found high innovators were more likely to use the methods and technologies than low innovators (Dobni & Klassen, 2021). The certification process is akin to the methods and technologies organizations use to execute innovation. In addition, the auditing processes strengthen the certification processes as well as the innovation culture, similar to how a strong stage-gate process supports a high innovating organization. The ESG certification process acts as a methodology to advance innovation and ESG agendas. For example:

Certifications that contain frameworks or require a framework stand in for methods and technologies in their absence and enhance existing [frameworks]. B Corp certification provides a subset of initiatives that are used to assess organizational scores toward compliance. They can be used by the organization to provide imperatives in any one of the five categories where they are lacking. They can also be used to improve an organization's scores by further refining existing initiatives. For example, the "workers" category scores

Figure 2. Innovative ESG Certification Framework key concepts



convey information about an organization's interaction with [its] employees and may be used to improve conditions. Further, these scores are available on B Lab's website, showing the overall score as well as individual category scores.

Given the complexities and breadth of certification terminology, we provide a summary of key certifications and terms discussed in this article in the [Appendix](#).

6. Final thoughts

The Innovative ESG Certification Framework is meant to provide guidance to leaders who are considering ESG certifications. It is a stark reminder to complete the due diligence to assess their organization's capabilities for obtaining and supporting an ESG certification. A full and complete view of the total cost of ownership is also required prior to ESG certification. Our view is that ESG certifications can enhance innovation culture and, therefore, improve firm performance in addition to ESG. A summary of the Innovative ESG Certification's key concepts is described in [Figure 2](#), illustrating the key actions, insights, and costs, as well as how they support an enhanced innovation culture.

Our concluding thoughts in Section 6 leverage lessons learned from innovation to complement the Innovative ESG Certification Framework. A summary of examples provided in this article is presented in the [Appendix](#). Below, we highlight three overarching lessons gleaned from this article:

1. **ESG is here to stay.** History is populated with transformational innovation events, products,

and discoveries—be it the light bulb, the internet, or the iPhone. Today, few would argue that innovation has decreased in importance. Regardless of the motivation, ESG permeates publications, government policies, boardroom discussions, news stories, and capital markets. Falling behind is not recommended and will prove to be costly, as many firms have lost significant competitive ground or become extinct due to a lack of innovation.

2. **Build synergies with existing priorities.**

Organizations that have multiple separate strategies (i.e., an innovation strategy, technology strategy, product strategy, corporate strategy, or department strategy) are misaligned and prone to failure. Leaders should not add a separate, distinct ESG strategy but rather integrate ESG priorities into the existing strategy. Successful innovative organizations do not silo innovation but develop innovative cultures across all aspects of their operations.

3. **Leadership signals, employees follow.**

The most important control system, priority, or strategy in an organization is "whatever the boss pays attention to." This is a phrase the authors have used with managers and employees to assist in communication and organizational execution. It is meant to highlight the importance of leadership and the critical role of signaling vision, and ESG is no different. If leaders continually and honestly place ESG at the top of their execution agendas, employees will follow, and culture will begin to form.

Appendix. Summary of certification examples and terminology

Key certification & terminology	Description	Information source & company examples
B Corp	A designation awarded by B Lab, a nonprofit organization. The designation certifies the company has a high standard in social and environmental performance, accountability, and transparency.	https://www.bcorporation.net/en-us/certification/ Example companies B Corp-certified: • Patagonia, • Ben & Jerry's • Greyston Bakery (US)* • New Belgium Brewing (US)*

(continued)

Key certification & terminology	Description	Information source & company examples
		• Better World Books (US)* • Ecover (Belgium)* • Innocent Drinks (UK)*
Biodynamics	Biodynamics is a holistic and ecological approach to farming, gardening, and food production.	https://www.biodynamics.com/
Demeter International	Demeter International is a large nonprofit that certifies organizations for biodynamics.	https://demeter.net/ Example companies biodynamic certified by Demeter: • Southbrook Winery (Canada)* • Marian Farms (US)* • Sekem (Egypt) • Bonterra Organic Vineyards (US) • Seven Stars Farms (US)*
Green bonds	Green bonds is a general term for bonds issued to fund projects with environmental or sustainable projects. The International Capital Market Association provides a set of Green Bond Principles.	https://www.icmagroup.org/sustainable-finance/the-principles-guidelines-and-handbooks/green-bond-principles-gbp/ Examples of institutes that issue green bonds: • World Bank Green Bonds • European Investment Bank
Climate Bonds Initiative (CBI)	Climate Bonds Initiative is an international nonprofit with a mission to mobilize capital for climate action. It certifies organizations, develops the green bond markets, and acts as a policy advocate. CBI-Certified Bonds are a green bond that meets strict climate change standards set by the Climate Bonds Initiative.	https://www.climatebonds.net/ Example of green bonds that are CBI-certified: • New York Metropolitan Transportation Authority (US) • Japan Railway Construction (Japan) • SolarCity (US)* • Renovate America (US)* • Fastpartner (Sweden)*
International Living Future Institute (ILFI)	International Living Future Institute is a nonprofit focused on advancing sustainable building practices, materials, and communities. ILFI certifies organizations in the building industry, (e.g., Zero Carbon Certification, Living Product Challenge Certification, and Living Building Challenge Certification).	https://living-future.org/ Example companies ILFI-certified: • Zero Carbon Certification ◦ Archimania (US)* ◦ Alfa Campus (Israel) • Living Building Challenge ◦ Google (Gradient Canopy Office) (US) ◦ Mithun (US)*
Environmental Certified Management Standard (ECMS)	Environmental Certified Management Standard is a general term to describe frameworks and certifications with commitments to improving environmental sustainability. Biodynamic certification would be an example of ECMS.	Examples of ECMS frameworks and certifications: • LEED (Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design). • ISO 14001 • Carbon Trust • Green Mark

* Denotes a small/medium enterprise (SME).

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